

INTRODUCTION

Janai's dream was to work as an assistant teacher with young children. That wasn't her only dream though. Janai shared, "My heart said, I want to be in college. College has been my dream." To make both dreams a reality, Janai attended Virginia Commonwealth University's (VCU) ACE-IT in College program.

While attending VCU, Janai engaged in paid campus jobs and internships that would prepare her for her future career.

Paid employment is important in college. Not only does it help students pay for college expenses while gaining work experience, but paid employment is a predictor of post-school employment for students attending inclusive postsecondary education (IPSE) programs (Grigal et al., 2019). Accessing paid employment opportunities can involve many different partners.

MEET THE PARTNERS

Janai certainly wasn't alone in her college journey as she prepared for her career. She had partnerships that supported her and provided opportunities for growth and development. Janai and the ACE-IT in College program staff worked collaboratively with a variety of partners. Partners included Virginia's vocational rehabilitation agency, the Department for Aging and Rehabilitative Services (DARS), job coaches, campus employers, an internship business site, and an organization that provided supported employment services post-graduation.

HOW PARTNERSHIP ENHANCES PAID OPPORTUNITIES

Even before her first semester at VCU, Janai's DARS counselor supported her as she applied to the program. Once enrolled, DARS attended Janai's person-centered planning meetings that helped to guide the types of paid campus jobs she would get, advised Janai on her career goals, and provided valuable input as Janai and staff from ACE-IT in College developed an academic and career plan that aligned with her goals.

The ACE-IT in College program and DARS have an agreement that provides funding to the program and students. Through this funding, Janai had access to job coaches. ACE-IT in College job coaches helped her get

The Think College Inclusive Higher Education Network established the Employment Partnerships Collaborative Workgroup to promote and improve collaboration between college and university programs for students with intellectual disability (ID) and entities that can support the employment and career goals of their students. The workgroup also develops resources to raise awareness, highlight promising practices, and replicate successful employment partnership activities.

paid campus jobs and internships and provided on-the-job training throughout each semester.

DARS also funded job coaching as Janai graduated from VCU and started her career search. The new job coach worked closely with ACE-IT in College's program staff to help Janai find opportunities after graduation. Program staff shared information on Janai's strengths, interests, experiences, and preferences and used their networks and job leads to help in the search.

Some of the most important partners in Janai's journey while in college were the employers. Building relationships with employers for paid employment strengthens IPSE programs. ACE-IT in College's employment staff works hard to build relationships with employers across the campus and community. These relationships, paired with Janai's skills and passions, led to interest-driven employment opportunities. While in college, Janai worked as a classroom assistant at VCU's Child Development



Janai celebrating her graduation from the ACE-IT in College program at Virginia Commonwealth University

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Center and a communication assistant at VCU's Office of Continuing and Professional Education. She wrapped up her final semester in college as a teacher's assistant at the Virginia Museum of Fine Arts early childhood education program.

OUTCOME OF PARTNERSHIP

The collaborative partnerships during Janai's college experience led to strong paid employment outcomes. Because of these partnerships, Janai had access to paid campus employment and internships that allowed her to explore her interests and refine necessary technical and workplace readiness skills with the support of trained job coaches.

Janai graduated from college with a strong resume and skills that would help her in her career search. Because of the relationships built between program staff, DARS, and a local organization that provides supported employment services, Janai could smoothly transition from college into the career search process and eventually on to her dream job.

Program staff was overjoyed to receive the news from Janai that she now works as a teacher's assistant in a local preschool!

Janai always "had a heart for teaching and wanted to impact children's lives," and that is exactly what she is doing! Janai's determination and skills ultimately led her to take advantage of every opportunity she got to excel. The partnerships between the program, state agencies, students, and employers paved the way for opportunities, support, and guidance that Janai used to reach her career goals.

WHAT CAN YOU DO?

Collaborative employment partnerships are an important part of any IPSE program. Looking to grow your employment partnerships? Here are some first steps:

- » Start with **assessing** what partnerships you already have and which ones are missing from your program. Assess how you might want to collaborate with various partners (e.g., partners in obtaining paid employment, funding partners, or other labor, services, or financial resource partners) to enhance paid employment opportunities.
- » Next, **research** what partnerships other programs in your state or across the country have built that have been beneficial to paid employment opportunities. Reach out to Think College, experts in the field, and other program directors to get advice. Research local, state, and federal policies and practices that support system-wide engagement with IPSE programs that could lead to increased paid employment opportunities.
- » Then, begin to **build relationships and collaboration**. Start to network and build relationships with campus, community, and agency partners. Get involved. Make your program well-known. You can begin to bring systems together for better employment outcomes!

WANT ASSISTANCE WITH DEVELOPING EMPLOYMENT PARTNERSHIPS?

For assistance or more information on strengthening employment partnerships within your program, organization, or state, visit [Think College Inclusive Higher Education Network](#).



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